

FUTURE SKILLS SERIES

AI Literacy • Lesson 3 of 6

THE FACT DESK LESSON

Hallucination Hunters

Fact-checking AI for grades 6–8: AI predicts **likely** words, so it can be confidently wrong. Students staff a newsroom fact desk, lateral-read every claim, and stamp the verdict: run, fix, or kill.

Grades 6–8

45-min lesson

No prep • No devices needed



STUDENT SESSION • THE COMET

The Fact Desk



Name: _____ Class: _____ Date: _____

MEMO — from Deja, editor-in-chief of The Comet: "Welcome to the fact desk. You're hired. Three of our writers used an AI helper on their drafts. Heads up: AI predicts *likely* words — it doesn't check them — so it can be flat-out wrong in a totally confident voice. Nothing runs until your desk clears it."

Your method, every draft: **1. UNDERLINE** every checkable claim (names, dates, numbers, places, quotes). **2. RANK** — write **C** above claims to CHECK, **S** above SAFE ones. **3. LATERAL-READ** — log where a second, independent source could confirm each C. **4. VERDICT** — stamp it, back it up, and say whether the writer's big conclusion still stands once the facts are fixed.

🔍 DRAFT #1 — PRIYA'S SCIENCE COLUMN, "MOON FACTS"

The Moon is Earth's only natural satellite. Astronauts first landed on the Moon in 1959, and Neil Armstrong was the first person to walk on its surface. In total, twelve people have walked on the Moon. On a clear night the Moon seems to shine because it produces its own light — which is why it's the brightest thing in the night sky.

CLAIM I MARKED C (CHECK)

SECOND SOURCE: WHERE I'D VERIFY IT

Verdict (circle one): RUN (clean) · FIX (correct it, then run) · KILL (cut the story) — **Note to Priya (your evidence):**

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A 45-minute AI fact-checking lesson. The hook: students get hired at a newsroom fact desk, and nothing runs until they clear it. They learn why AI can be confidently wrong — and the four-step method that catches it.

AT A GLANCE

TIME	MATERIALS	TECH NEEDED	PREP
45 min	The Fact Desk worksheet (1 per student)	None — fully unplugged; devices only add	Print worksheets. That's it.

OBJECTIVES

- Students can explain why AI "hallucinates": it predicts likely words, so it can be confidently wrong.
- Students can identify the checkable claims in a text — names, dates, numbers, places, quotes, and rank them by risk.
- Students can lateral-read a claim (verify it against a second, independent source) and deliver an evidence-based verdict: RUN, FIX, or KILL.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

CCSS ELA RI.6.8

ISTE 1.3.b

ISTE 1.3.d

Full text + taught/assessed map for each grade in the Teacher Guide.

WARM-UP — THE STORY THAT ALMOST RAN (7 MIN)

Read this aloud, smooth and confident, like a news anchor. Then ask for a vote: "This is going in tomorrow's paper. **Print it?**"

"Our solar system has eight planets orbiting one star, the Sun. The closest planet to the Sun is Venus, which is also the hottest. Mars is called the Red Planet because rusty iron dust covers its surface. Saturn is famous for its rings — it is the only planet in our solar system that has them. Sunlight takes about eight minutes to reach Earth."

Most classes vote print. Reveal: **two claims are false**. Mercury is closest to the Sun (Venus really is the hottest — the half-truth makes it slippery), and Saturn isn't alone: Jupiter, Uranus, and Neptune have faint rings too.

Bridge: "That paragraph sounded right because it was SMOOTH, not because it was TRUE. AI talks like that all the time — it predicts likely words, it doesn't check them. Today you're the fact desk: nothing runs until you clear it."

 DRAFT #2 — THEO'S QUIZ PAGE, "WORLD RECORDS CORNER"

The Pacific Ocean is the largest ocean on Earth. The Nile River flows north through Egypt and is one of the longest rivers in the world. The tallest mountain above sea level is Mount Everest, which rises in the Andes range in South America. Earth has seven continents, and the largest is Asia. Australia's capital city is Sydney. Put it together and the record-holders sit on three continents: Africa, South America, and Asia.

CLAIM I MARKED C (CHECK)	SECOND SOURCE: WHERE I'D VERIFY IT

Verdict (circle one): RUN • FIX • KILL — Note to Theo (your evidence):

PREVIEW • FULL DOWNLOAD HAS 3 PRINT-READY PDFS